

## Introduction:

The nine-month-long Liberation War of Bangladesh was a dynamic conflict defined by a critical transition from widespread, uncoordinated **spontaneous resistance** to a highly structured and strategically executed **sector-based battle**. This dual approach, combining the patriotic zeal of the masses with professional military planning, was key to achieving final victory.

## Phase I: Spontaneous Resistance (March 26 – Early April 1971)

The spontaneous resistance was the immediate, unorganized national reaction to the Pakistani military's brutal **Operation Searchlight** launched on the night of March 25, 1971.

**Nature:** This phase was characterized by an immediate, passionate, and localized defense against the invading forces, often initiated without central command or comprehensive planning.

### Key Activists/Participants:

**Bengali Military & Para-Military:** Defecting Bengali officers and soldiers from the East Bengal Regiment (EBR), East Pakistan Rifles (EPR), and Police (most notably the initial resistance at Rajarbagh Police Lines).

**Students, Political Activists, and the General Populace:** They rapidly formed groups, erected roadblocks (like the one at Farmgate in Dhaka), and used whatever available weapons they had to resist.

**Result:** While heroic and crucial for establishing the initial declaration of independence and demonstrating national resolve, the resistance's scattered nature and inferior equipment forced the fighters to retreat into India to reorganize under a unified command.

## Phase II: Sector-Based Strategic Battle (Mid-April – December 1971)

Following the initial retreats, the Provisional Government of Bangladesh (Mujibnagar Government) formally established a unified military structure under Commander-in-Chief

Colonel M. A. G. Osmani. The entire country was strategically divided into **eleven geographical sectors** to conduct sustained military operations.

The fighting forces, known collectively as the **Mukti Bahini** (Liberation Forces), were organized into two main wings within these sectors:

- 1. **Regular Forces (Niyomito Bahini):** Organized forces of former Pakistani military personnel, trained for conventional warfare. Three large brigades—**Z-Force** (under Lt. Col. Ziaur Rahman), **K-Force** (under Lt. Col. Khaled Mosharraf), and **S-Force** (under Lt. Col. K. M. Shafiullah)—were formed for major frontal assaults.
- 2. **Guerrilla Forces (Gono Bahini):** Composed of trained civilians, students, and activists who excelled at **guerrilla warfare**, sabotage, ambushes, and disrupting the Pakistani Army's supply lines and communications.

**The Eleven Sectors and their Commanders**

The following table details the geographical area and commanders for the eleven sectors:

| Sector No. | Geographical Area Covered                                                           | Sector Commander(s)                                                             | Key Operations/Focus                                                                           |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1          | Chittagong District, Chittagong Hill Tracts, and Eastern part of Noakhali District. | <b>Major Ziaur Rahman</b> (Initial) \$to\$ <b>Major Rafiqul Islam</b>           | Held crucial hilly terrain and eastern flanks; focused on large-scale conventional operations. |
| 2          | Dhaka, Comilla, and Faridpur Districts, and part of Noakhali District.              | <b>Major Khaled Mosharraf</b> (Initial) \$to\$ <b>Major ATM Haider</b>          | Included the capital and was a major hub for guerrilla warfare and sabotage in central Bengal. |
| 3          | Part of Comilla and Sylhet Districts (Area between Churaman Kathi and Singerbil).   | <b>Major K. M. Shafiullah</b> (Initial) \$to\$ <b>Major A. N. M. Nuruzzaman</b> | Critical for controlling key border posts and supply routes into central Bengal.               |

|          |                                                                               |                                                                              |                                                                                                       |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>4</b> | Part of Sylhet District (From Habiganj to Kanaighat).                         | <b>Major Chittarajan Datta (C. R. Datta)</b><br>\$to\$ <b>Captain A. Rob</b> | Focused on holding positions along the long border and launching attacks in the Sylhet region.        |
| <b>5</b> | Part of Sylhet District (From Durgapur to Dawki).                             | <b>Major Mir Shawkat Ali</b>                                                 | Heavily relied on guerrilla tactics in the difficult, forested terrain of the northern Sylhet region. |
| <b>6</b> | Rangpur and part of Dinajpur District.                                        | <b>Wing Commander M. Khademul Bashar</b>                                     | Fought in the flat, northern plains; involved a mix of regular and Gono Bahini actions.               |
| <b>7</b> | Rajshahi, Pabna, Bogra, and part of Dinajpur District.                        | <b>Major Nazmul Huq (Initial)</b> \$to\$ <b>Major Quazi Nooruzzaman</b>      | Known for intense guerrilla operations and the decisive <b>Battle of Hilli</b> in the final stage.    |
| <b>8</b> | Jessore, Kushtia, Khulna, Satkhira, and part of Faridpur District.            | <b>Major Abu Osman Chowdhury (Initial)</b> \$to\$ <b>Major Abul Manzoor</b>  | Focused on the important southwestern border areas, including the vital Benapole front.               |
| <b>9</b> | Barisal and Patuakhali Districts, and parts of Khulna and Faridpur Districts. | <b>Major M. A. Jalil (Initial)</b> \$to\$ <b>Major M. A. Manzur</b>          | Focused on operations in the difficult riverine and coastal areas of Southern Bengal.                 |

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|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 10 | Naval Commandos                                                      | Commander-in-Chief (M. A. G. Osmani)                                | Not a land sector, but a floating unit for operations across all sea and river routes, notably <b>Operation Jackpot</b> . |
| 11 | Mymensingh and Tangail Districts, and parts of Rangpur and Dinajpur. | Major Abu Taher (Initial) \$to\$ Squadron Leader M. Hamidullah Khan | Key area for the famous <b>Kaderia Bahini</b> and operations in the central-northern plains.                              |

## Conclusion

The Liberation War's structure was a brilliant adaptation to the realities of fighting a superior army. The initial **spontaneous resistance** ignited the mass movement and ensured the people's total commitment. This energy was then channelled into the systematic and strategic framework of the **eleven sectors**, which allowed for a coordinated national effort. The Mukti Bahini, led by the sector commanders and supported by countless local activists (the Gono Bahini), employed a classic low-intensity guerrilla strategy that eventually wore down the Pakistani forces, paving the way for the joint conventional offensive that secured independence.